

Gym Equipment Guide

Free Weights

Equipment	Best For	Notes
Barbell	Compound lifts (squat, bench, deadlift, OHP)	Allows heaviest progressive loading
Dumbbells	Unilateral work, stabilizer engagement	Good for balancing left/right strength
Kettlebells	Ballistic/dynamic movements (swings, cleans)	Useful for conditioning and power

Machines

Equipment	Best For	Notes
Cable Machine	Constant tension, isolation work	Very versatile with different attachments
Leg Press	Quad/glute volume with lower technical demand	Good option when back-loaded squats aren't ideal
Smith Machine	Fixed-path pressing/squatting	Useful for isolating muscle without balance demand
Lat Pulldown/Row Machines	Back training with adjustable resistance	Good entry point before pull-ups

Accessories

Resistance bands: add variable tension, useful for warm-ups, mobility, and assistance work (e.g., banded pull-ups).

Lifting belt: can support heavier compound lifts (squat, deadlift) by increasing intra-abdominal pressure; not required for all training.

Wrist straps/wraps: assist grip on heavy pulling movements or support wrists on heavy pressing.

Foam roller: used for self-myofascial release, often as part of a warm-up or recovery routine.

Building a Minimal Home Gym

Priority order for limited budget/space: adjustable dumbbells, resistance bands, a pull-up bar, then a bench, then a barbell + plates if space allows.

A well-chosen minimal setup can support a full progressive training program without a commercial gym.